It's About Transformation

with poems by Turiya Autry and Walildah Imarisha (aka Good Sista/Bad Sista)

INTRODUCTION

Spoken Word poets Turiya Autry and Walildah Imarisha create magic with their voices -- anthems, alive with rhythm, fire, and unapologetic pride. They call out the myths and stereotypes placed on Black women and replace them with voices that demand to be heard, seen, and celebrated.

This performance of their poetry isn't about entertainment, it's about transformation.

Supa Soul Sistas and No You Don't Know Me by Turiya Autry and Walidah Imarisha

Supa Soul Sistas (Pgs 340-345)

i always wanted to be a superhero marvel comic book character
action packed thrill a minute type of girl
just hug my curves and hold your breath

but i'd do it with a twist,
cause i didn't want to be no wonder woman or bionic woman
and i definitely didn't want to be invisible woman
(I did that every day)

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no, i wanted to be a black female superhero
kicking a** and looking damn good
i wanted to be storm from the x-men
command the elements with a single thought
shake entire continents with my wrath
and quiet the fiercest monsoons

i used to wish to be storm
so when some stupid *person*
asked me why i was so angry
my eyes would widen
with the awesome power of nature

i would raise my hands above my head
power pulsating in between my fingertips
i would make the sky darken and rumble my answer
and then from the bowels of the clouds
a lightning bolt would flash

i knew then that no known image of black women,
created by white men
(of course)
could satisfy my longing to be a superhero
i would have to figure it out for myself
i would have to make myself over into . . .

a supa sooooooullllll sista!

that's right
the white man will not be saving the universe this time

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not Willis, not Schwarzenegger, not Ash Ketchum, and not
that bratty whiny Skywalker

instead the next superhero is a sister
and not the generic, ratings are going down
we need something to perk up the show
safeway select of superheroes
generic brand of freedom fighter

no, this will be a sister
who can fly above the chains of ignorance
and whip out the tongue lashing of a lifetime

"you think you know me?
i call upon the forces of Isis and Harriet Tubman
Sojourner Truth and Nefertiti
Assata Shakur and Cleopatra
to reign down the fury of centuries of oppression
degradation and silence on your head
because we will not be silent anymore

or maybe my power would be held captive
trapped like an angry storm cloud whipping out of my
head
my hair would rise up around me like a cobra's hood
spitting venom and years of pent up frustration
of not good enough, not light enough, not white enough
and you can touch it if you want to
but I can't be responsible for the consequences!
instead,

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i'll be responsible for conquering corporate dominance
ending racial profiling with a swift crackdown
coming soon to a theater
(and streets) in your town!
then I can tap into my special super empathy powered
third eye . . .
and I . . .
sense. . .
racism nearby . . .

damn, girl, that ain't a super power
that's just simple common sense!

you're right! every black woman
action figure or not
comes equipped with that option

KAPOW

take that for slavery
and that's for segregation
and that's for integration
that's for the glass ceiling
and that's for that futuristic movie
where i am still Aunt Jemima
talking bout "have a cookie and you'll feel better"
and this is for my not ever being able to find
flesh colored pantyhose
or my hair care products at the corner store

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KABLAM!

knocked that smirk right off the face of patriarchy
rewrote history and started my own galaxy
beyond the silver surfer's reach
cause you know he be trying to gentrify that s***
and no the chief of police can't page us with a strobe light
shaped like an afro pick shining on the night's sky
Charlie won't be on the intercom
and if he tries to page us tell him
we've decided to stop moonlighting as angels
cause we've come down to earth
and pawned our wings

cause we are Supa Soooooooullll Sistas
and you just found your way
onto the bad side of our hair

No You Don't Know Me (Pgs 345-350)

	Black folks
Woman	
	Colored
Women	
	African American
I am	
	Black
We are	
	Mulatto
Names	
	Darkie
Titles	
	Mammy
Assigned	
	High Yella
But who are we	
	Jezebel
Really?	
	N****

People are always trying to categorize us, demystify us.
Flatten us and straighten us and define us our parameters.
But they really don't have a clue.

Don't I know you? You look so familiar!

No you don't know me!
I didn't used to sit next to you in second period math class
I wasn't friends with your second cousin's best friend
And no you didn't see me on *Soul Train*
But thanks for asking

Black
I am the universe before the stars
Fertile chamber of things to come
Buried secrets
Deep beneath the ground
Deep beneath the deck of slave ships named jesus
We multiply and reproduce
A mass movement coming from the underground

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Grassroots taking over the landscape
We clone ourselves in preparation for the slave insurrection

Do you get confused when
More than one black person enters the room?

Colored
I am muted brown
Child of Ham
Searching for a sign
To point me in
The right direction
But that path is labeled whites only.
How can you know me when you're afraid to get close to me?

Is it a genetic drift
That pushes you
To the other side of the elevator every time I get on?
If you think you're scared now, you should hear what we say when you're not around . . .

You know, Portland is the whitest major city in amerika
We used to be number two but now Omaha has that honor!
Moving on up! (Moving on down!)
Surrounded
Don't get me wrong . . .
Trapped behind every lines

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I'm not a racist . . .
Closing in from all sides
I mean some of my best friends are . . .
May day! May day! This is not a drill!
I repeat this is not a drill
This is reality!

It's just that every once in a while
We would like to get away!
I mean, they even show up at reggae shows! ***Bomba Clot!***

We may be only 3 percent of Oregon's population
But goddamnit, we're taking over!!!

We don't have any smiles for you today
We're throwing in our masks
We're not going to steppin fetchit for you anymore
The minstrel show is over!

And for as much as we remain silent with our thoughts,
Seems like white folks don't have problems expressing what they think:

It's not like you're black; it's more like you're white . . .
Oh you speak so well!
You're so lucky. It's like you have a year round tan!
You're so angry. Why are you so gosh darn angry?
Can I touch your hair?!

HELL NO!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!

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Tonight on the six o'clock news
An epidemic of jungle fever is running rampant
Spreading throughout the nation
Causing white boys to get pretty bold!

You know, white girls just don't do it for me.
I don't know why.
I don't date anything lighter than a cinnamon.
Baby, can I get some of your brown suga?

Interracial relationships
From the slave quarters to the big screen
Wasn't part of Martin's "I Have a Dream"
Look, Black isn't some two-hour movie
Starring Oscar award winning performances
Or some thirty-minute laugh track sitcom
Where widened grins mask our suffering.

We are more than MTV personifications
twenty-first-century reinterpretations of slave plantations

Forget everything *Good Times* ever taught you
About black folks:
DYNOMITE!
And just listen . . . really listen
So when you say that you *"know me"*
You can say it with honesty.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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